

Source Amnesia Trace Student Handout

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Knowledge and the Knower • 20-30 min

Category	Knowledge and the Knower	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	source-amnesia-trace

Big idea: Remembering a claim is not the same as remembering why it deserved trust.

Student-Facing Prompt

Inspect Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: Claim: 'Spacing revision improves long-term memory' paired first with 'cognitive scientist', then later shown without source. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Claim: 'Blue light glasses double focus' paired first with 'online advert', then later shown without source. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Source Amnesia Trace Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Claim: 'Blue light glasses double focus' paired first with 'online advert', then later shown without source. Before discussing, write what you noticed, what you inferred, and how confident you are.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Remembering a claim is not the same as remembering why it deserved trust.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students
1	After inspecting Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?
2	Which exact detail from Source Amnesia Trace Stimulus A did you use as evidence?
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?
6	What happens to justification when we forget the source of a belief?

Ready-to-Use Examples

- Claim: 'Spacing revision improves long-term memory' paired first with 'cognitive scientist', then later shown without source.
- Claim: 'Blue light glasses double focus' paired first with 'online advert', then later shown without source.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to Knowledge and the Knower.

Activity Steps

1. Show students a short set of claims, each paired with a different source type.
2. After a distractor task, give students the claims again without sources.
3. Students mark whether they remember the claim and then identify its original source.
4. Reveal the source pairings and compare content memory with source memory.
5. Debrief how source memory affects justification and responsible belief.

Observation and Evidence Record

Use this grid to keep observation, inference, evidence, and confidence separate.

What I noticed	What I inferred	Evidence	Confidence

TOK Debrief

- Knowledge question: What happens to justification when we forget the source of a belief?
- Can a claim become more or less credible in memory?
- How should knowers track where their beliefs came from?

Knowledge Questions

- What happens to justification when we forget the source of a belief?
- Is remembering that something is true enough for knowledge?
- How does source memory affect responsible knowing?

Transfer Example

For example, run this activity with students remember a claim but lose track of whether it came from expert, friend, ad, or rumour. Have students commit to an initial claim, then reveal the change, hidden rule, alternative context, or comparison that makes the knowledge problem visible.

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...